

Knee Replacement for Arthritis – UK Guide

Considering a knee replacement for arthritis? UK guide to NHS eligibility, surgery types, waiting times, recovery timeline, and physiotherapy after surgery.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-01-30 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Around **100,000 knee replacements** are performed each year in the UK, most for osteoarthritis. It's one of the most successful operations in modern medicine, with over 95% of patients reporting significant pain relief. Here's what you need to know about the process in the UK.

When Is Knee Replacement Recommended?

Knee replacement is considered when:

- Pain is severe and affecting your quality of life
- Non-surgical treatments (exercise, weight loss, physiotherapy, injections) haven't provided sufficient relief
- X-rays show significant joint damage
- You have difficulty with daily activities like walking, climbing stairs, or sleeping

There's no strict age limit — suitability is based on need and overall health.

Types of Knee Replacement



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- Total knee replacement (TKR) — the entire joint surface is replaced. Most common type.
- Partial (unicompartmental) knee replacement — only the damaged section is replaced. Smaller operation, faster recovery, but not suitable for everyone.
- Revision surgery — replacing a worn-out previous replacement (less common).

NHS Waiting Times

Current NHS waiting times for knee replacement vary significantly by region:

- England: average 6-12 months, some areas longer
- Scotland, Wales, Northern Ireland: similar variation
- You can check hospital waiting times at nhs.uk

- Remember: you have the right to choose your hospital in England
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What to Expect



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Before Surgery

- Pre-assessment clinic — blood tests, ECG, general health check
- "Prehab" exercises — strengthening exercises before surgery improve recovery
- Optimise weight and stop smoking if applicable

The Operation

- Usually under spinal anaesthetic (you're awake but numb from the waist down)

- Takes approximately 1-2 hours
- You'll usually stay in hospital for 1-3 days

Recovery Timeline

- Weeks 1-2 — walking with crutches, starting physiotherapy exercises
 - Weeks 3-6 — increasing mobility, reducing crutch use
 - Weeks 6-12 — most people return to driving and light activities
 - 3-6 months — significant improvement in pain and function
 - 12 months — maximum benefit usually achieved
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Physiotherapy After Surgery

Physiotherapy is crucial for a good outcome:

- NHS physiotherapy is provided post-operatively
 - Exercises focus on regaining range of motion and strength
 - You'll be given a home exercise programme to follow daily
 - Consistency with exercises is the single biggest factor in recovery
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Risks and Considerations



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- Infection risk: approximately 1-2%
- Blood clot risk: reduced with medication and compression stockings
- Implant lifespan: modern replacements last 20-25+ years
- Stiffness: some people need manipulation under anaesthetic if the knee doesn't bend well

Knee replacement is a major decision. Discuss all your options with your orthopaedic surgeon, and remember that preparation and post-operative physiotherapy are key to the best outcomes.

Q&A

Question: When Is Knee Replacement Recommended?

Short answer: Knee replacement is considered when: Pain is severe and affecting your quality of life Non-surgical treatments (exercise, weight loss, physiotherapy, injections) haven't provided sufficient relief X-rays show significant joint damage You have difficulty with daily activities like walking, climbing stairs, or sleeping There's no strict age limit — suitability is based on need and overall health.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk